GEORGETOWN UNIVERSITY

Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>

something is going very wrong

10 messages

Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:27 AM
To: Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>, Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>

apropos recent linkedin posts,

Higher education enrollment in Chile has grown dramatically, with gross enrollment increasing from 14% in 1990 to over 50% by 2011, driven by private sector expansion, increased vocational training (IPs and CFTs), and policies like the 2016 "gratuidad" (free tuition). By 2020, over 400,000 students were beneficiaries of free tuition, shifting focus toward retention and on-time graduation. National Institutes of Health (.gov) +3

So, some basic calculations:

if you were college age in 1990, you were probably 40-45 in 2013, when PIACC did its first adult literacy tests. Then, in the data, the PIACC scores for 40-45 year olds is around 220. Which tells us that 0.15*X + 0.85*Y = 220, where X is the score for college goers and Y is the score for non college-goers.

Now, if you fast forward to 2011, the people who were college age in 2011 are probably around 30-35 in 2023, and their PIACC scores are around 238. So that tell us that 0.5X1 + 0.5Y1 = 238, which at first looks like there has been some improvement, but you have to also account for the fact that scores fall with age, and if you calibrate that properly, you get back to around 220! So, now you have 0.5X1 + 0.5Y1 = 220 as well, which is bizarre and suggests massive declines in the actual gains from going to college.

What is going on?

Can someone look into downloading the PIACC data.....

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Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:35 AM
To: Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>

Hmm very interesting just requested which countries would you like?
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Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:35 AM
To: Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>, Ethan Sager

<es1772@georgetown.edu>

This is super concerning!!!!!!!!! I can download the PIAAC data tomorrow..
Eva

On Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:28 AM Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu> wrote:
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Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:37 AM
To: Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>, Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>

shall we all write a joint blog for CGD on this topic? Did OECD literacy peak in 2015?

Perhaps we can use an agentic workflow and see how that works....spring break project for those of us who are here? we can spend half a day on it....would be interesting to see. The more I dive into this, the weirder and weirder it gets.....

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Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:40 AM

To: Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>, Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>

This is a great idea! I set up a folder on das-human-kapital called piaac has chile round 1 and 2 seems like it makes sense to dump all of the OECD in there.

Ethan
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Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:44 AM
To: Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu>, Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>

Great idea!
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Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 11:46 AM
To: Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>, Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>

if of interest, here are the participating countries. I was telling yash that there are 3 forces driving down literacy:

1. The score within age-group is declining
2. The score as you age is declining
3. Populations are getting older

If you put all these things together and project it forward, things are looking disastrous in another 10-20 years. Choose whichever ones you are interested in.

Italy has 33% functional illiteracy....just sayin" #LPIM

Participating Countries

Education system	PIAAC Cycle 1			PIAAC Cycle 2
	Round 1 2012	Round 2 2014	Round 3 2017	Round 1 2023
Australia	•			
Austria	•			•
Belgium (Flemish)	•			•
Canada	•			•
Chile		•		•
Croatia				•
Cyprus[1]	•			
Czech Republic	•			•
Denmark	•			•
Ecuador			•	
Estonia	•			•
Finland	•			•
France	•			•
Germany	•			•
Greece		•		
Hungary			•	•
Indonesia		○		
Ireland	•			•
Israel		•		•
Italy	•			•
Japan	•			•
Kazakhstan			•	
Korea, Republic of	•			•
Latvia				•
Lithuania		•		•
Mexico			•	
Netherlands	•			•
New Zealand		•		•
Norway	•			•
Peru			•	
Poland	•			•

New Zealand		●		●
Norway	●			●
Peru			●	
Poland	●			●
Portugal				●
Russian Federation	○			
Singapore		●		●
Slovak Republic	●			●
Slovenia		●		
Spain	●			●
Sweden	●			●
Switzerland				●
Turkey		●		
United Kingdom (England)	●			●
United Kingdom (Northern Ireland)	●			
United States	●	See note[2]	●[3]	●
Total	Round 1 25	Round 2 8	Round 3 8	Round 1 31
	PIAAC Cycle 1 38[4]			PIAAC Cycle 2 31

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Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 3:15 PM

To: Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>, Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>

Ruby Frazer-Dalby reacted via Gmail

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2 attachments

image.png
44K

image.png
34K

Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu> Thu, Feb 26, 2026 at 4:50 PM
To: Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>, Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>

the mystery now has deepened further. Below, I am copying Chile's performance on the PISA, which tests 15 year olds. In the test, 1sd is around 100 points so Chile's increase from 2000 to 2009 is around 0.4sd, which is massive.

Chile — PISA mean scores (points)

PISA cycle	Reading	
2000	410	National Center ...
2003	—	
2006	442	National Center ...
2009	449	National Center ...
2012	441	National Center ...
2015	459	National Center ...
2018	452	OECD
2022	448	gpseducation.oe...

THEN

Here are the Chilean 16-24 year olds in 2013 PIACC, basically verging on illiteracy. So, these must be people who are around 15 years old in 2009 and were doing really well in the PISA. For some reason, they left school and suddenly became functionally illiterate, despite having the best scores in PISA for a long time.

Chile — mean literacy score (0–500 scale), by age group

Age group	Mean literacy score
16–24	237.0 National Center ...

Even worse, now if you look at the 25-34 year olds, who must have been around 15 in the 2000 and therefore did really badly in the PISA, it turns out that the are just as literate as the 16 year olds, despite the 16-year olds having great scores.

Chile — mean literacy score (0–500 scale), by age group

Age group	Mean literacy score
16–24	237.0 National Center ...
25–34	235 National Center ...

FINALLY, here is 2023. 15 year olds in 2000 and now 35-44, and they have a score of 219, but the 15 year olds in 2009 are now in the 25-34 and they have precisely the same scores as the 25-34 year olds in 2013, despite having seen massive gains in PISA.

For the **2023 Survey of Adult Skills (PIAAC Cycle 2), Chile's mean literacy scores (0–500 scale)** by age group are:

Age group	Mean literacy score
16–24	242 OECD Education...
25–34	238 OECD Education...
35–44	219 OECD Education...
45–54	206 OECD Education...
55–65	181 OECD Education...

WHAT is going on???? These guys are even more low-performing than the italian men....

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[Quoted text hidden]

Jishnu Das <Jishnu.Das@georgetown.edu> Sat, Feb 28, 2026 at 5:59 PM
To: Eva Langbehn <ecl91@georgetown.edu>
Cc: Yash Dhuldhoya <ynd3@georgetown.edu>, Ruby Frazer-Dalby <rof6@georgetown.edu>, Ethan Sager <es1772@georgetown.edu>

and here is the staggering media coverage.

Outlet	Domain	Access via web tool	2014 wave (30d window)	2017 wave (30d window)	2023 wave (30d window)
New York Times	nytimes.com	Blocked (robots)			
Wall Street Journal	wsj.com	Accessible	0	0	1
Washington Post	washingtonpost.com	Accessible	1	0	0
Associated Press	apnews.com	Accessible	1	0	0
Reuters	reuters.com	Accessible	0	0	0
NPR	npr.org	Blocked (robots)			
CNN	cnn.com	Blocked (robots)			
ABC News	abcnews.go.com	Accessible	0	0	0
NBC News	nbcnews.com	Blocked (robots)			
CBS News	cbsnews.com	Accessible	0	0	0

Education Week	edweek.org	Accessible	1	2	1
Chronicle of Higher Education	chronicle.com	Accessible	0	0	0

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